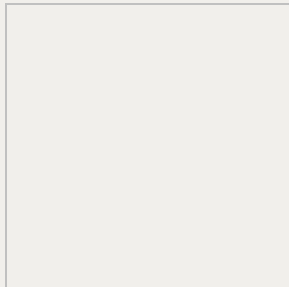


IN CONTEXT

The devil myth

Paganini's breathtaking, almost superhuman virtuoso violin-playing led to the popular belief that he was "the devil's fiddler." A slick showman and astute businessman, the composer was quick to cultivate a demonic persona. Skeletal, with long hair, pale skin, sinewy hands, and sunken cheeks (exaggerated after losing his teeth in 1828), he would appear on stage dressed from head to toe in black, often with a single spotlight accentuating his bizarre appearance. Sometimes, he would ride in a black carriage drawn by black horses. The diabolic associations greatly boosted box-office sales. However, it has been claimed that Paganini's appearance and dexterity may have been partly due to Marfan and Ehlers-Danlos syndromes—conditions leading to long, thin limbs and joints and ultra-flexibility. Whatever the cause, such was the power of the myth that the Catholic Church refused to bury him.



DAGUERREOTYPE, BELIEVED TO BE OF PAGANINI

One of six children, Paganini was born in the port city of Genoa in 1782. His father, probably a dock worker, was an amateur musician who taught his son to play the mandolin and the guitar. By the age of eight, Niccolò was also learning to play the violin and composing his own work; he gave his first concert aged 11 and soon after this went on his first tour.